Chapter Sixteen

Monks and Brahmans

Between 1150 and 1189, the king of Sri Lanka takes control of both his island and its monasteries, and a Hindu prophet tries to bring new power to the people

JUST OFF THE SOUTHERN TIP of the Indian subcontinent, a Buddhist hero was crowned king.

A century earlier, the island of Sri Lanka had been dominated by the empire of the Chola: the greatest southern Indian empire that had ever existed, a rich kingdom that stretched east all the way to the islands of Java and Sumatra and north as far as the Narmada river. The Chola king was a devotee of the Hindu god Shiva; temples to Shiva and *lingams*—seamless pillars with no features, representing the all-encompassing, transcendent essence of Shiva—dotted the massive expanses of Chola land.

That land had reached its greatest extent in the late eleventh century. And then, bits of it had begun to flake away. Off the southern coast, a rebel named Vijaya Bahu had declared himself king of the entire island; Chola troops, crossing the water, managed to retake the north, but Vijaya Bahu held on to the south until his death.

His sons and grandsons ruled after him, but the island remained splintered even after the Chola abandoned their claim. The ancient chronicle of Sri